DRAFT

Practice Finding Utility Shutoffs

Learn where your controls are before an emergency. This is a **look, label, photograph, and explain** drill—not a reason to interrupt service.

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Do not operate a control just to practice. Never open or remove equipment covers, break a utility seal, enter a restricted area, or guess. Ask the utility or a qualified electrician or plumber to identify an uncertain control and demonstrate any permitted action.

BEFORE YOU WALK AROUND

- ☐ Tell everyone this is a no-shutoff walk-through. Bring this sheet, a phone or camera, a permanent label, and a flashlight.
- ☐ Have an adult who can reach the control safely attend. Plan assistance or an alternate person if strength, vision, mobility, or dexterity could make access difficult.
- ☐ Use only a provider-approved tool of the correct size. Store it in a known, dry, accessible place near—but not attached to or obstructing—the equipment.
- ☐ Photograph a wide view showing the route and a close view showing the control and label. Do not photograph account numbers, keys, access codes, or other sensitive details.
- ☐ Keep the route clear. Make sure labels identify the correct home or unit without covering warnings, vents, meters, seals, or operating instructions.

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× DANGER — STOP NOW

Stop the entire drill and keep away if there is fire, smoke, sparks, arcing, a gas odor, or hissing. Do not touch a switch, control, phone, garage-door opener, vehicle, flame, or anything else that could create a spark near a suspected gas leak. Leave by a safe route, warn others, and contact emergency services and the utility from a safe location.

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Practice Finding Utility Shutoffs — continued

ELECTRICITY

Locate, record, and explain

1. From a dry, unobstructed position, locate the service panel and the main disconnect identified for your home. Multi-unit buildings may have controls managed by the owner or utility.
2. Read the existing label without opening an equipment cover. Ask a qualified electrician to correct missing, confusing, or mismatched labels.
3. Photograph the route, panel location, and main-disconnect label. Record the location below.
4. Point without touching and say: “This is the main electrical disconnect. In an emergency I will follow the utility, fire service, or electrician's instructions. I will approach only if the area and equipment are dry, intact, and free of fire or sparking.”

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Electricity stop conditions: Stop and keep away from a damaged, hot, buzzing, smoking, or exposed panel; standing water or wet equipment; sparks or arcing; fire; or a control you cannot reach without climbing, moving debris, entering a restricted space, or approaching another hazard. Do not touch the panel or use a tool. Call emergency services for immediate danger and notify the electric utility or a qualified electrician from a safe place.

Electric utility: _____ **Emergency number:** _____
Main disconnect location: _____
Required tool, if provider/electrician specifies one: _____
Photo saved/printed at: _____ **Date:** _____

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Practice Finding Utility Shutoffs — continued

WATER

Locate, record, and explain

1. Locate the home's main water shutoff. Distinguish it from fixture valves, irrigation controls, fire-sprinkler controls, and any utility-owned street or meter valve.
2. Check that the route is clear and the label is readable. Do not enter a flooded space or force a buried, corroded, leaking, or stuck valve.
3. Photograph the route, a wide view, and the labeled control. Ask the water provider or a qualified plumber which control residents may operate and which tool, if any, is correct.
4. Point without turning and say: “This is my home water shutoff. I know which direction and tool the provider or plumber specifies. I will not operate a utility-owned or fire-suppression control unless authorized.”

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Water stop conditions: Stop if the control is inaccessible; submerged or surrounded by standing water; near exposed wiring or electrical equipment; damaged, leaking, badly corroded, or stuck; or if reaching it requires entering an unsafe space. Do not force it. Keep away from electrical hazards and call the water utility, property manager, or a qualified plumber; call emergency services for immediate danger.

Water utility: _____ **Emergency number:** _____
Home shutoff location: _____
Required tool, if provider/plumber specifies one: _____
Photo saved/printed at: _____ **Date:** _____

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Practice Finding Utility Shutoffs — continued

NATURAL GAS

× DANGER — STOP NOW

Follow your gas utility provider's instructions about when to shut off gas. Rules and equipment vary. Do not shut off gas merely for this drill. If gas is shut off for any reason, **never turn gas service back on yourself**; only the utility or another professional specifically authorized by the utility may restore service and relight appliances.

Locate, record, and explain—without touching

1. Using the provider's information, identify the meter and resident-operable shutoff, if any, from a safe outdoor position. Do not confuse appliance valves with the service shutoff.
2. Do not touch or test the valve. Do not remove a cover, break a seal, dig, or enter a utility-only or locked area.
3. Photograph the safe approach, meter, and provider-identified shutoff without including the meter/account number. Record the provider-specified tool and keep it accessible only if the provider directs.
4. From well away from the equipment, say: “I will shut off gas only when my gas provider instructs me to do so. If I smell gas or hear hissing, I will leave without operating anything that could spark, then call from a safe location. I will never restore gas service myself.”

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! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Gas stop conditions: Stop, do not approach or touch the meter, and leave the area for any gas odor, hissing, damaged pipe or meter, fire, smoke, sparks, or inaccessible control. Do not search for the leak or attempt a repair. From a safe location, call emergency services and the gas utility as their instructions direct.

Gas utility: _____ **Emergency number:** _____
Provider-identified shutoff location: _____
Provider-required tool: _____
Photo saved/printed at: _____ **Date:** _____

Practice Finding Utility Shutoffs — continued

FINISH THE NO-SHUTOFF PRACTICE

1. Have another household member use the photos and written clues to locate each control without touching it.
2. Take turns describing who to call, the provider's conditions for shutoff, the safe approach, the correct tool, and every reason to stop.
3. Correct labels and access problems through the provider, property manager, or qualified trade professional. Do not modify utility equipment yourself.
4. Review after moving in, changing providers, remodeling, or learning that equipment or instructions changed. Replace outdated photographs.

HOUSEHOLD RECORD AND FUTURE HOME & UTILITIES SECTION

This hands-on sheet is for recognition and verbal rehearsal. Keep durable provider instructions, inspection or repair records, diagrams, account-safe contact information, and restoration planning in the future **Home & Utilities** section. When that section is added, it should refer back to this drill rather than duplicate the practice steps.

Practice partner: _____ **Practice date:** _____ **Next review:** _____
Accessible tool-storage location: _____
Person who can help or act if I cannot: _____

⌖ **LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE APPROVAL**

LOCAL PROVIDER DETAILS — [VERIFY] BEFORE USE OR PUBLICATION

[VERIFY] Electric provider's shutoff and emergency instructions: _____
[VERIFY] Water provider's resident-operable control, tool, and instructions:
_____
[VERIFY] Gas provider's conditions for shutoff, approved tool, and emergency instructions: _____
[VERIFY] Local emergency number and fire-service instructions:
_____

Do not fill this block from memory, a search result, or a neighbor's procedure. Confirm directly with each responsible provider or authority; record the representative or official source and date.

Verified by/source: _____ **Date:** _____

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Practice Finding Utility Shutoffs — continued

REQUIRED TECHNICAL AND FIRE-SERVICE REVIEW

Do not approve or publish this handout until the reviews below are complete. Obtain review of the applicable controls, tools, stop conditions, emergency contacts, and local-info block from each relevant local utility. Where a utility will not review interior customer-owned equipment, obtain review from a qualified electrician for electrical content and a qualified plumber for water content. Also obtain a separate fire-service review of the emergency actions and fire, spark, and gas-leak language.

Electric utility / qualified electrician: _____ **Role/license:** _____
Water utility / qualified plumber: _____ **Role/license:** _____
Gas utility representative: _____ **Role:** _____
Fire-service reviewer: _____ **Agency/role:** _____
Review dates and corrections completed: _____

SOURCES

Sources: Ready.gov, “Safety Skills”; Pacific Gas and Electric Company, “Natural Gas Safety.” Accessed 2026-09-29. Provider-specific procedures and contacts remain [VERIFY] pending the local reviews recorded above.